



Pasteis de Nata ~ Portuguese Custard Tarts



4.82 / 325 votes

This pastéis de nata recipe makes as-close-to-authentic Portuguese custard tarts with a rich egg custard nestled in shatteringly crisp pastry. Tastes like home, even if you're not from Portugal.

Prep Time 1 hr	Cook Time 1 hr 30 mins	Total Time 2 hrs 30 mins
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Course: Dessert Cuisine: Portuguese Servings: 40 pastries Calories: 105

Equipment

- 1 Mini-muffin tin or...
- 12 Classic pastéis tins
- 1 Candy thermometer

Ingredients

FOR THE PASTEL DE NATA DOUGH

- ☐ 2 cups minus 2 tablespoons all-purpose flour, plus more for the work surface
- ☐ 1/4 teaspoon sea salt
- ☐ 3/4 cup plus 2 tablespoons cold water
- ☐ 2 sticks (8 oz) unsalted butter, room temperature, stirred until smooth

FOR THE CUSTARD

- ☐ 3 tablespoons all-purpose flour
- ☐ 1 1/4 cups whole milk, divided
- ☐ 1 1/3 cups granulated sugar
- ☐ 1 cinnamon stick
- ☐ 2/3 cup water
- ☐ 1/2 teaspoon vanilla extract
- ☐ 6 large egg yolks, whisked

FOR THE GARNISH

- ☐ confectioners' sugar
- ☐ ground cinnamon

Instructions

MAKE THE PASTEL DE NATA DOUGH

1. In a stand mixer fitted with a dough hook, mix the **2 cups minus 2**

tablespoons all-purpose flour, 1/4 teaspoon sea salt, and 3/4 cup plus 2 tablespoons cold water

until a soft, pillowy dough forms that pulls away from the side of the bowl, about 30 seconds.

2. Generously flour a work surface and pat the dough into a 6-inch (15-cm) square using a pastry scraper. Flour the dough, cover with plastic wrap, and let it rest at room temperature for 15 minutes.
3. Roll the dough into an 18-inch (46-cm) square. As you work, use the scraper to lift the dough to make sure the underside isn't sticking to your work surface.
4. Brush the excess flour off the top of the dough, trim any uneven edges, and, using a small offset spatula, dot and then spread the left 2/3 portion of the dough with a little less than 1/3 of the **2 sticks (8 oz) unsalted butter** being careful to leave a 1 inch (25 mm) plain border around the edge of the dough.
5. Neatly fold the unbuttered right 1/3 of the dough (using the pastry scraper to loosen it if it sticks) over the rest of the dough. Brush off any excess flour, then fold over the left 1/3 of the dough. Starting from the top, pat down the dough with your hand to release any air bubbles, and

then pinch the edges of the dough to seal. Brush off any excess flour.

6. Turn the dough 90° to the left so the fold is facing you. Lift the dough and flour the work surface. Once again roll it out to an 18-inch (46-cm) square, then dot the left 2/3 of the dough with 1/3 of the butter and smear it over the dough. Fold the dough as directed in steps 4 and 5.
7. For the last rolling, turn the dough 90° to the left and roll out the dough to an 18-by-21-inch (46-by-53-cm) rectangle, with the shorter side facing you. Spread the remaining butter over the entire surface of the dough.
8. Using the spatula as an aid, lift the edge of dough closest to you and roll the dough away from you into a tight log, brushing the excess flour from the underside as you go. Trim the ends and cut the log in half. Wrap each piece in plastic wrap and chill for 2 hours or preferably overnight. (The pastry can be frozen for up to 3 months.)

MAKE THE CUSTARD

9. In a medium bowl, whisk the **3 tablespoons all-purpose flour** and **1/4 cup of the milk** (60 ml) until smooth.
10. Bring the **1 1/3 cups granulated**

sugar, 1 cinnamon stick, and **2/3 cup water** to a boil in a small saucepan and cook until an instant-read thermometer registers 220°F (104°C). Do not stir.

11. Meanwhile, in another small saucepan, scald the remaining **1 cup milk** (237 ml). Whisk the hot milk into the flour mixture.
12. Remove the cinnamon stick and then pour the sugar syrup in a thin stream into the hot milk-and-flour mixture, whisking briskly. Add the **1/2 teaspoon vanilla extract** and stir for a minute until very warm but not hot.
13. Whisk in the **6 large egg yolks**, strain the mixture into a bowl, cover with plastic wrap, and set aside. The custard will be thin; that is as it should be. (You can refrigerate the custard for up to 3 days.)

ASSEMBLE AND BAKE THE PASTRIES

14. Place an oven rack in the top third position and crank the oven to 550°F (290°C) for at least 30 minutes. The oven needs this time to maintain this blazing hot temperature.
15. Remove a pastry log from the refrigerator and roll it back and forth on a lightly floured surface until it's about an inch (25 mm) in diameter and 16 inches (41 cm)

long. Cut it into scant 3/4-inch (18-mm) pieces. Place 1 piece pastry dough, cut side down, in each well of a nonstick 12-cup mini-muffin pan (2-by-5/8-inch [50-by-15-mm] size).

 **TESTER TIP:** If using classic egg tart tins, cut the dough into generous 1-inch (25-mm) pieces. Allow the dough pieces to soften for several minutes until pliable.

16. Have a small cup of water nearby. Dip your thumbs in the water, then straight down into the middle of the dough spiral. Flatten it against the bottom of the cup to a thickness of about 1/16 inch (1.5 mm), then smooth the dough up the sides and create a raised lip about 1/8 inch (3 mm) above the pan. The pastry bottoms should be thinner than the tops.
17. Fill each cup 3/4 full with the cool custard. Bake the pastries until the edges of the dough are frilled and brown, about 8 to 9 minutes for the mini-muffin tins, 15 to 17 minutes for the classic tins.
18. Remove from the oven and allow the egg tarts to cool a few minutes in the pan, then transfer to a rack and cool until just warm. Sprinkle the pasteis generously with **confectioners' sugar**, then **ground**

cinnamon and serve. Repeat with the remaining pastry and custard. These are best consumed the day they're made.

Notes

1. **Pastry making**--When making the pastry, make sure the butter is evenly layered, all excess flour is removed, and the dough is rolled very thin and folded neatly.
2. **Tending to the custard**--You'll need a thermometer to gauge the custard accurately.
3. **Timing**--Portuguese egg tarts are

best eaten warm the day they're made.

Variation

If you'd like a citrus kiss to your custard, add two 2-inch lemon peels along with the cinnamon stick in step 10.

Nutrition

Serving: 1 mini pastel | Calories: 105kcal |
 Carbohydrates: 12g | Protein: 1g | Fat: 6g
 | Saturated Fat: 3g | Monounsaturated
 Fat: 2g | Trans Fat: 0.2g | Cholesterol:
 41mg | Sodium: 38mg | Fiber: 0.2g |
 Sugar: 7g